

Who Pays for Senior Tax Exemptions?

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Context and Feedback Requested

Key question: Do senior property tax exemptions raise or lower tax rates for non-seniors? More ambitiously, what is the incidence of senior tax preferences, generally?

Identification Strategy: Difference-in-differences exploiting staggered adoption of senior exemptions across jurisdictions.

Data Status: The Georgia Property Tax Database from Banzhaf et al. (2021) would be an ideal place to start. It has exemption laws and rates for all Georgia jurisdictions from 1990–2013. Access is restricted; I have requested it but may not receive it. The alternative is building my own panel, which is feasible but would likely require 1–2 months.

Feedback requested: Is there a faster way to test whether this idea will work before investing time in data collection? I’m looking for ways to fail fast.

1 Idea overview

Motivation

One explanation for age-based tax preferences is political pandering to a powerful voting bloc (Mulligan and Sala-i Martin, 1999). But at the municipal level, there is a fiscal rationale: while seniors are costly for the federal government, they are fiscal assets for local governments. They pay property taxes but consume few costly local services, particularly K-12 education (see Table 1). This creates a fiscal surplus that municipalities may rationally compete for.

Localities attract seniors through both income and property tax exemptions.

On the income side, 41 states exempt Social Security entirely, and state income tax liabilities for 65+ households are 10–58% lower than for similar younger households. (Brewer et al., 2017) estimates that about 7% of state income tax revenue is spent on senior income tax exemptions. Appendix Table 4 contains more examples.

Property tax exemptions are similarly widespread (see Table 2). No comprehensive national estimate exists, but individual state costs are large. Texas’s 2025 increase in the homestead exemption for 65+ or disabled homeowners is projected to cost the state approximately \$600 million

annually, and municipalities offer additional exemptions beyond state-level ones. Many exemptions have no income limits, so wealthy retirees receive the same benefit as those on fixed incomes.¹

These policies induce sorting: Banzhaf et al. (2021) estimate that Cobb County’s 100% school tax exemption for those 62 and older increased the county’s senior homeowner population by 32–54%.

Who bears the cost of these exemptions? If exemptions are offset by higher rates on non-seniors, the subsidy is a direct transfer from younger to older residents. If senior in-migration expands the tax base enough to lower rates for everyone, the policy may be self-financing for the jurisdiction that adopts it (though not in aggregate). I hope to estimate what happens to tax rates on non-seniors when jurisdictions adopt senior exemptions.

Related literature

Several papers study senior migration directly: Badilla Maroto et al. (2024) establish that senior migration raises French house prices (by approximately 1%) and tax revenues (property tax revenues by 1.3%, land tax revenues by 2.8%). Banzhaf et al. (2021) show that age-based property tax exemptions induce substantial senior sorting, but do not trace through the fiscal consequences for non-exempt taxpayers.

The US context differs from France in ways that matter for welfare: US localities rely heavily on property taxes to fund K-12 education, creating a fiscal link between household composition and school spending. Seniors who pay property taxes represent a potential subsidy to families—but only if localities do not compete away this surplus through age-based exemptions.

An older literature finds that elderly population share is negatively associated with education spending (Poterba, 1997; Ladd and Murray, 2001; Harris et al., 2001). These papers study elderly population associations, not elderly tax breaks—the latter is my focus.

2 Seniors as Fiscal Assets

Table 1 provides illustrative calculations of the fiscal impacts of a senior household vs. a younger family for a **municipality**, assuming no senior tax exemptions. Education spending is large and mainly financed by local governments, so the number of children in a household is first-order for a household’s fiscal impact on a municipality. The table excludes income taxes, since most municipalities do not impose an income tax.

Municipalities also provide senior-specific property tax relief, partially offsetting the fiscal benefits of senior migration. Senior property tax relief operates through three mechanisms: (1) direct exemptions that reduce assessed value by a fixed dollar amount or percentage; (2) senior-specific assessment freezes that lock in a base-year valuation; and (3) general assessment caps that limit annual increases for all homeowners but disproportionately benefit long-tenure residents. Table 2 illustrates how these mechanisms interact in three large counties, assuming house prices in those counties grew at the same rate as they did nationally.

¹Texas Legislative Budget Board, Fiscal Note for SB 23, 89th Legislature. Available at <https://capitol.texas.gov/tlodocs/89R/fiscalnotes/html/SB00023F.htm>.

Line Item	Per Unit	70-Yr Couple	Family of 4
<i>Assumptions</i>			
Household Composition	—	2 Adults (65+)	2 Adults, 2 Children
Assessed Home Value	—	\$350,000	\$350,000
<i>Revenue Generated</i>			
Property Tax (2% effective)	—	\$7,000	\$7,000
Sales Tax & Other	\$1,996/capita	\$3,992	\$7,983
Total Revenue	—	\$10,992	\$14,983
<i>Marginal Cost of Services</i>			
Public Education (K–12)	\$6,860/pupil	\$0	\$13,719
Other Local Services	\$6,555/household	\$6,555	\$6,555
Total Marginal Cost	—	\$6,555	\$20,274
<i>Net Fiscal Impact</i>			
Surplus / (Deficit)	—	+\$4,437	(\$5,291)

Table 1: Illustrative marginal fiscal impact of new residents on local government. *Revenue*: Property tax assumes 2% effective rate on assessed value. Sales tax & other includes local sales taxes, charges, and fees (\$1,996/capita = \$662B total non-property local own-source revenue $\div$ 331.9M population). *Expenditure*: Education calculated as local direct expenditure on elementary and secondary education (\$753B) divided by public K–12 enrollment (49.4M students). Other local services calculated as local direct general expenditure excluding education (\$1123B) divided by 129.9M households, covering police, fire, roads, sewerage, parks, courts, and administration—services that primarily serve households rather than individuals. Education expenditure reflects local-funded share only (45%, per NCES). For other services, 55% of K–12 spending is allocated to state/federal transfers (\$414B), leaving \$353B for non-education—implying a 76% local share. Source: U.S. Census Bureau, 2021 Annual Survey of State and Local Government Finances; population and households from Census Bureau; enrollment from NCES.

In Harris County, a senior turning 65 saves \$2,140 annually through Texas’s homestead exemption, regardless of tenure. In Cook County, the direct exemption saves only \$520, but the senior freeze delivers \$3,510 for a long-tenure homeowner. In Los Angeles, Proposition 13’s assessment cap saves a 25-year owner \$1,790. The cap is not senior-targeted but delivers most of its benefits to long-tenured homeowners. Comparing these mechanisms is not straightforward: exemptions deliver immediate savings, while freezes deliver a subsidy whose present value depends on expected tenure and housing appreciation.

Table 2: Annual Property Tax Bills by Senior Status and Tenure: \$300,000 Home (2024)

Jurisdiction	Homeowner Profile			
	Non-Senior (2024 Buyer)	Senior 65 (2024 Buyer)	Senior 65 (1999 Buyer)	Senior 75 (1989 Buyer)
<i>Panel A: Annual Property Tax Bill (\$)</i>				
Cook County (Chicago) ^a	\$5,270	\$4,750	\$4,750	\$1,760
Harris County (Houston) ^b	\$4,430	\$2,290	\$2,290	\$1,870
Los Angeles County ^c	\$3,510	\$3,510	\$1,720	\$1,640
<i>Panel B: Savings Relative to Non-Senior 2024 Buyer (\$)</i>				
Cook County (Chicago)	–	\$520	\$520	\$3,510
Harris County (Houston)	–	\$2,140	\$2,140	\$2,560
Los Angeles County	–	\$0	\$1,790	\$1,870
<i>Panel C: Effective Tax Rate (% of \$300k Market Value)</i>				
Cook County (Chicago)	1.76	1.58	1.58	0.59
Harris County (Houston)	1.48	0.76	0.76	0.62
Los Angeles County	1.17	1.17	0.57	0.55

Notes: Assumes \$50,000 household income. Historical purchase prices estimated using S&P Case-Shiller U.S. National Home Price Index appreciation (4.9% annually for 1999–2024; 4.3% annually for 1989–2024). For columns 3–4, assessed values reflect market appreciation until the homeowner turned 65 and qualified for applicable freeze programs.

^a Cook County 2024: 10% assessment ratio, 3.0355 equalization factor, ~6.5% composite tax rate on EAV. Exemptions: homeowner (\$10,000 EAV), senior 65+ (\$8,000 EAV, income <\$65,000). Senior Freeze locks EAV at age 65. Column 4 assumes EAV frozen in 2014 at \$167,000 market value.

^b Houston/Harris County 2024 rates: Houston School District 0.87%, City of Houston 0.52%, Harris County entities 0.60% (county, hospital district, port, flood control). Exemptions: general homestead (school \$100,000; city/county 20%), senior 65+ (school additional \$10,000; City of Houston \$260,000; Harris County \$229,000). School taxes frozen at age 65. Column 4 assumes school taxes frozen in 2014 at \$167,000 home value with \$25,000 exemption.

^c California Proposition 13: assessed value equals purchase price, capped at 2% annual growth; tax rate ~1.17% (1% base plus local bonds). No senior-specific exemption.

3 Descriptive Patterns: Where are seniors moving?

If financial considerations dominate senior migration decisions, tax preferences could induce substantial sorting—even if poorly targeted to need. If amenities dominate instead, exemptions mostly subsidize inframarginal seniors who would have lived there regardless. This section explores

correlates of senior migration over 2010–2020.

Net migration is estimated as a residual: actual 2020 population minus the aged-forward population (the 2010 cohort aged 55+, minus deaths). This approach accounts for aging in—a county’s 65+ population can only exceed the aged-forward count through in-migration, not locals getting older. See Appendix B for details. All right-hand-side variables are measured at the 2010 baseline.

Table 3 reports correlates of senior net migration. State income tax rate is not statistically significant. Seniors moved to counties that already had large senior populations, avoided low-density areas, and favored the South and West. They moved to counties with high healthcare employment shares, high median household incomes, and low median house values.² These patterns suggest amenities matter more than taxes for location choice, raising the possibility that exemptions primarily subsidize inframarginal seniors rather than inducing new migration.

4 Research Design: Do Senior Property Tax Exemptions Raise or Lower Rates for Non-Seniors?

If seniors are fiscal assets for municipalities, a natural question is whether this surplus accrues to seniors themselves (via property tax exemptions) or is passed through to other taxpayers (via lower tax rates or improved services). Income tax relief varies only at the state level, limiting identification. Property tax exemptions, by contrast, vary across thousands of local jurisdictions and change over time. Age-based property tax exemptions induce substantial senior sorting (Banzhaf et al., 2021), but the incidence on non-seniors remains unexplored.

4.1 Research Question and Regression Equation

What happens to property tax rates on non-exempt properties when jurisdictions adopt senior exemptions? The basic specification is a difference-in-differences:

$$\text{NonSeniorTaxRate}_{jt} = \alpha_j + \gamma_t + \beta \cdot \text{SeniorExemption}_{jt} + \varepsilon_{jt} \quad (1)$$

where j indexes jurisdictions and t indexes years. $\text{SeniorExemption}_{jt}$ is either a binary indicator for whether jurisdiction j has a senior exemption in year t , or a continuous measure of exemption generosity (e.g., dollar value of the exemption). The coefficient β captures the effect of adopting (or expanding) a senior exemption on millage rates.

1. **Rates rise** ($\hat{\beta} > 0$): The exemption creates a revenue hole filled by higher rates on non-seniors.
2. **Rates fall** ($\hat{\beta} < 0$): Senior in-migration generates fiscal surplus that benefits non-seniors.

²The 65+ share coefficient is not mechanical. It would be zero if movers distributed themselves randomly across counties or if there were no migration at all.

Table 3: Correlates of Senior Net Migration Rate (2010–2020)

	<i>Dependent Variable: Net Senior Migration Rate, 2010–2020</i>			
	OLS		WLS	
	Coef.	Partial R^2	Coef.	Partial R^2
<i>Demographic Variables</i>				
Pop. 65+ Share (z)	3.178*** (0.799)	0.053	3.954*** (0.957)	0.081
Log Total Population (z)	1.712** (0.850)	0.007	-2.599** (1.129)	0.026
Bottom Quartile Pop. Density	-3.430*** (0.613)	0.046	-4.639*** (0.640)	0.031
Top Quartile Pop. Density	0.442 (0.414)	0.001	1.702** (0.681)	0.013
<i>Geographic & Climate Variables</i>				
Region: South	2.645*** (0.803)	0.033	3.867*** (0.797)	0.061
Region: West	2.787*** (0.697)	0.025	4.701*** (0.905)	0.069
Coastal County	-1.109** (0.438)	0.009	-1.380*** (0.424)	0.030
Natural Amenities Scale (z)	0.547 (0.615)	0.001	0.635 (0.858)	0.002
<i>Economic Variables</i>				
Healthcare Empl. Share (z)	0.647** (0.286)	0.003	1.148** (0.545)	0.004
Manufacturing Empl. Share (z)	0.246 (0.267)	0.000	0.362 (0.451)	0.000
Median HH Income (\$000s) (z)	3.861*** (0.597)	0.044	4.667*** (1.510)	0.106
Median House Value (\$0000s) (z)	-2.357*** (0.846)	0.013	-3.299** (1.506)	0.075
State Income Tax Rate (z)	-0.234 (0.627)	0.000	-0.666 (0.611)	0.004
Intercept	4.045*** (0.703)	—	5.284*** (0.817)	—
Observations	3104		3104	
R^2	0.197		0.431	
Dep. Var. Mean	4.04		2.10	

* $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$. (z) = standardized.

SEs clustered at state level. WLS weights by expected 65+ population.

Partial R^2 = share of unexplained variance explained by predictor.

Net migration data from Egan & Robertson (2024).

3. **Rates unchanged** ($\hat{\beta} \approx 0$): Exemptions are set such that seniors are fiscally neutral for jurisdictions.

The specification will likely require lags—effects on property tax rates may show up only after seniors respond to the exemption and the tax base shifts.

4.2 Data Path Forward, Details

I am pursuing two parallel tracks:

1. **Georgia Property Tax Database.** The data used in Banzhaf et al. (2021) contains detailed exemption laws (age thresholds, income limits, exemption amounts) from 1938–2013, millage rates for all 159 Georgia counties, school districts, and municipalities from 1990–2013, and staggered adoption timing across jurisdictions. Access is restricted; I requested access last week but may not receive it.
2. **Build my own dataset.** Collect senior property tax exemption parameters for representative addresses in the 20 largest US metro areas. Appendix C contains some rough details on a couple policies. I haven’t started this yet.

The Georgia data would allow a clean difference-in-differences design with within-state variation. My own dataset would have more external validity but take time to compile.

References

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A State Income Tax Preferences

Table 4: State Income Tax Preferences for a Senior (Age 65+) with \$50,000 Income in the Ten Most Populous States

Income composition: \$25,000 Social Security + \$15,000 401k/pension withdrawals + \$10,000 other

State	Eff. Rate	Tax Due (Non-Sr.)	Savings	Tax Due (Sr.)	Sr. Eff. Rate
CA	2.7%	\$1,350	\$1,219	\$131	0.3%
TX	0%	\$0	\$0	\$0	0%
FL	0%	\$0	\$0	\$0	0%
NY	4.3%	\$2,150	\$2,070	\$80	0.2%
PA	3.07%	\$1,535	\$1,228	\$307	0.6%
IL	4.7%	\$2,346	\$1,980	\$366	0.7%
OH	1.2%	\$594	\$594	\$0	0%
GA	4.2%	\$2,086	\$2,086	\$0	0%
NC	3.4%	\$1,676	\$1,125	\$551	1.1%
MI	3.8%	\$1,887	\$1,700	\$187	0.4%

Notes: Effective rates include standard deductions. TX and FL have no income tax. Senior exemptions by state: CA exempts Social Security and provides a \$149 senior tax credit; NY exempts Social Security and up to \$20k in pension/retirement income; PA and IL exempt all retirement income (Social Security, pensions, 401(k), IRA); OH exempts Social Security (remaining income falls in 0% bracket); GA exempts up to \$65k in retirement income for seniors 65+; NC exempts Social Security only; MI exempts all retirement income.

B Net Migration Calculation

Net migration cannot be directly observed—there is no administrative data tracking every move. Instead, Egan-Robertson et al. (2024) estimate it as a *residual*:

$$\underbrace{\text{Net Migrants}_{65+}}_{\text{CALCULATED}} = \underbrace{\text{Pop}_{65+}^{2020}}_{\text{DATA}} - \underbrace{\text{Expected Pop}_{65+}^{2020}}_{\text{CALCULATED}} \quad (2)$$

$$\underbrace{\text{Expected Pop}_{65+}^{2020}}_{\text{CALCULATED}} = \underbrace{\text{Pop}_{55+}^{2010}}_{\text{DATA (Census)}} - \underbrace{\text{Deaths}_{55+}^{2010-2020}}_{\text{DATA (Vital Stats)}} \quad (3)$$

In words: Pop_{65+}^{2020} is the actual count of people aged 65+ in 2020 (from Census). Expected Pop_{65+}^{2020} is what the 65+ population *would have been* if nobody moved—starting from the 2010 population aged 55+ and subtracting deaths over the decade.

The expected population includes everyone who was 55–64 in 2010 and survived to become 65+ by 2020. So if a county’s actual 65+ population exceeds expectations, it must be due to in-migration, not just locals getting older.

The rate:

$$\text{Net Migration Rate} = \frac{\text{Net Migrants}_{65+}}{\text{Expected Pop}_{65+}^{2020}} \times 100$$

A value of 10 means net in-migration equal to 10% of the expected 65+ population over the decade.

C Data Path Forward

C.1 Why Existing Data Are Insufficient

The most comprehensive existing resource is the Lincoln Institute’s *Significant Features of the Property Tax* database, which documents property tax relief programs across all 50 states. However, this database operates at the *state* level: it records that New York authorizes a local-option senior exemption with income limits “between \$3,000 and \$29,000,” but does not document what each locality actually chose. The local parameters—which determine actual tax savings—are not systematically collected anywhere.

This matters because most senior property tax exemptions are locally determined. The Lincoln Institute notes that 48% of senior exemption programs are locally funded, meaning localities set the parameters. A state-level dataset cannot capture the variation needed to study how exemption generosity affects tax burdens on non-seniors.

C.2 Unit of Analysis: Representative Addresses

A further complication is that “jurisdiction” is not well-defined for property taxes. A homeowner’s tax bill reflects overlapping levies from the county, municipality, school district, and often multiple special districts—each of which may offer its own senior exemption. Rather than attempting to define jurisdictions, I propose selecting a *representative residential address* in the principal city of each metro area and documenting the full stack of exemptions that apply to that parcel. This makes the unit of analysis concrete and ensures all applicable programs are captured.

C.3 Data Template

For each representative address, the data collection documents each senior exemption program that applies to the parcel. Table 5 illustrates this template for two metros: New York City (a consolidated city with unified taxation) and Chicago (where county, municipal, and school district levies are separate).

Table 5: Part B: Senior Exemption Programs

Field	New York City		Chicago	
	Enhanced STAR	SCHE	Senior Exemption	Senior Freeze
Level	NY State	NYC	Illinois/Cook	Illinois/Cook
Age threshold	65	65	65	65
Income limit	\$98,700	\$50,000–58,399 [†]	None	\$65,000
Exemption type	\$ off school tax	% of AV	\$ off EAV	Freeze EAV
Magnitude	TBD (NYC amount)	5–50%	\$8,000	Base year EAV
Applicable levies	School only	All	All	All

Notes: NYC parameters from NY Dept. of Taxation and Finance and NYC Dept. of Finance. Chicago parameters from Cook County Assessor. The Senior Freeze does not freeze the tax bill—it freezes the EAV, so taxes can still rise if rates increase. Income limits are for 2024–25 (NYC) and 2024 (Chicago). [†]SCHE uses a sliding scale: 50% exemption for income $\leq$ \$50,000; partial exemptions (5–45%) for \$50,001–58,399.

Examples of variation. Cook County, IL increased its senior exemption from \$5,000 to \$8,000 EAV in 2017. NYC’s SCHE income limits were frozen from 2009 to 2024, then raised from \$29,000 to \$50,000. Even a nominally constant exemption creates real variation over time due to inflation, a point Saez (2003) exploits.

Table 6: Summary Statistics (2010 Baseline)

	Mean	SD	Min	Max
<i>Outcome Variables</i>				
Net Migration Rate 65+	4.04	11.71	-69.37	156.64
Δ Share 65+	3.35	2.07	-13.19	30.66
<i>Demographic Variables</i>				
Pop. 55-64 Share	13.21	2.13	4.01	28.05
Pop. 65+ Share	15.95	4.13	3.73	43.38
Log Total Population	10.28	1.45	4.41	16.10
Bottom Quartile Pop. Density	0.25	0.43	0.00	1.00
Top Quartile Pop. Density	0.25	0.43	0.00	1.00
<i>Geographic & Climate Variables</i>				
Region: South	0.45	0.50	0.00	1.00
Region: West	0.13	0.34	0.00	1.00
Coastal County	0.10	0.30	0.00	1.00
Natural Amenities Scale	0.05	2.28	-6.40	11.17
<i>Economic Variables</i>				
Healthcare Empl. Share	0.15	0.09	0.00	0.61
Manufacturing Empl. Share	0.11	0.11	0.00	0.71
Median HH Income (\$000s)	44.10	11.42	19.35	115.57
Median House Value (\$0000s)	13.15	8.72	2.97	100.00
State Income Tax Rate	5.29	2.73	0.00	11.00
Observations	3104			

All variables measured at 2010 baseline except outcome variables.

Table 7: Variable Definitions and Sources

Variable	Definition
<i>Outcome Variable (2010–2020)</i>	
Net Migration Rate 65+	Net migration rate for population 65+, 2010–2020. Defined as (net migrants)/(expected population) $\times$ 100, where expected population accounts for mortality. A value of 10 means net in-migration equal to 10% of the expected 65+ population over the decade. Source: Egan & Robertson (2024).
<i>Demographic Variables (2010 baseline)</i>	
Pop. 55–64 Share	Share of county population aged 55–64 (%). This cohort ages into 65+ during the study period. Source: 2010 Decennial Census SF1.
Pop. 65+ Share	Share of county population aged 65+ (%). Baseline elderly share. Source: 2010 Decennial Census SF1.
Log Total Population	Natural log of total county population. Source: 2010 Decennial Census SF1.
Bottom Quartile Pop. Density	Binary indicator equal to 1 if county is in bottom quartile of population density (persons per square mile).
Top Quartile Pop. Density	Binary indicator equal to 1 if county is in top quartile of population density.
<i>Geographic & Climate Variables (2010 baseline)</i>	
Region: South	Binary indicator for Southern Census region: AL, AR, FL, GA, KY, LA, MS, NC, OK, SC, TN, TX, VA, WV.
Region: West	Binary indicator for Western Census region: AZ, CA, CO, ID, MT, NV, NM, OR, UT, WA, WY.
Coastal County	Binary indicator for coastal county per NOAA definition. Source: NOAA coastal county list.
Natural Amenities Scale	USDA Natural Amenities Scale. Composite index based on climate (mild winters, warm winters, low summer humidity), topographic variation, and water area. Higher values indicate more favorable natural amenities. Source: USDA ERS.
<i>Economic Variables (2010 baseline)</i>	
Healthcare Empl. Share	Share of county employment in healthcare and social assistance sector (NAICS 62). Source: County Business Patterns 2010.
Manufacturing Empl. Share	Share of county employment in manufacturing sector (NAICS 31–33). Source: County Business Patterns 2010.
Median HH Income (\$000s)	Median household income, in thousands of dollars. Source: ACS 2006–2010 5-year estimates.
Median House Value (\$0000s)	Median value of owner-occupied housing units, in tens of thousands of dollars. Source: ACS 2006–2010 5-year estimates.
State Income Tax Rate	Maximum marginal state income tax rate (%). Source: Tax Foundation.